

BUBBLE TEA NEWS

Issue 7 · 28 August 2026 · Complimentary — please take one bubbletea.nz · est. 2026



BREAKING · BELLEVUE LANE

Café Trivia Leaderboards Turn Openly Competitive, Risk Assessed Low-to-Moderate

Case definition: any café chalkboard publicly ranking regulars by trivia-night win streak. Four boards as of Monday, up from one after a rival café chalked a regular's eleven-week streak in gold marker, apparently to poach her custom. The lane's business association has floated a "chalk only, no marker" rule to keep things civil, which nobody has yet agreed to follow.

community-outbreak-bulletin

MASTHEAD · NOW JOINING OUR PAGES

Bubble Tea News Welcomes Film Critic Kate Rodgers

The Editors

This issue marks the first byline for Kate Rodgers, who joins us after years running concessions and the floor at a suburban multiplex before crossing the counter to criticism herself. Her reviews run on what she calls the Refill Rating: how many times she got up for more popcorn during the film, where zero is the highest compliment going. Her debut column runs opposite. Welcome, Kate.

EDITORIAL · MENACE WATCH

The Meadowbank Swan: Hero or Menace?

Gordon Slate, Editor-in-Chief

A figure in a full swan costume has been spotted along the Meadowbank strip handing bent-straw swans to children and, this paper must note, keeping the lunch-rush queue suspiciously orderly while doing it. Orderly! A costumed operative with unrestricted access to a queue's timing, a strip's foot traffic, and, I remind readers, its cutlery, does not "help." It positions. I am offering my usual bounty — a lifetime pearl-milk-tea card and one full year of free upsizing — for a clear photograph of whoever is under that beak. I would recognize her voice anywhere, incidentally, having been served my own bubble tea by it not two hours before sitting down to write this column. Unmask yourself, Swan. This paper is watching. So, apparently, is everyone else, at considerable speed.



FILM · NEW RELEASE ROUNDUP

Two Tickets, One Empty Popcorn Box

"Skyclaw: Reckoning," the fourth entry in a franchise that keeps insisting it has more story left, is a four-refill picture — I know because I checked, twice, once during an eleven-minute hangar scene that exists purely so the sound mix has something to do. Nobody in my session minded the wait at the counter either; the queue outside practically qualified as sponsored content. Across the hall, a quiet little drama called "The Long Wait" earned something I haven't given out since I started this job: zero refills. Zero. I sat through the whole thing with a full box going warm in my lap, because I genuinely could not risk missing a line of it. That's the review, really. Go see the one where I stayed in my seat.

Kate Rodgers

SHOPPING · SEEKER'S EYE

One Charm, Buried Under Thirty Swan Decoys

Winnie Zhao

Everyone's searching "swan bag charm" this week — thank you, Meadowbank — and thirty near-identical listings are cashing in on it with the same stretched stock photo. One seller, four pages deep, actually stitches the neck seam by hand; you can tell from the one honest close-up shot they forgot to touch up. That's the one I'd chase.

BUBBLE TEA TRIVIA

Did You Know?

Hong Kong-style milk tea — made with black tea and evaporated or condensed milk, no pearls involved — is a separate tradition entirely, tracing to British colonial-era tea culture and predating Taiwan's pearl-topped bubble tea by decades.



In Every Issue

A new logic puzzle

Fresh local trivia

A rotating cast of columnists

Local ad space, weekly

Menace Watch, monthly — the editor's turn

"Zero refills. Zero. I sat through the whole thing with a full box going warm in my lap."

— Kate Rodgers, on "The Long Wait"

JOKE OF THE WEEK

What did the boba say to the milk tea? You're brew-tiful together.

Overload NZ 2026

26–27 Sept · NZ International Convention Centre. Cosplay, artists & guests incl. Ladybeard, Chelsey Furedi & Rin Sakura. Tickets: overload.co.nz — about four weeks out.



LIFESTYLES · CHAMPAGNE WISHES

Inside the Ashgrove-Pemberton Convention Green Room

Champagne wishes and caviar dreams, darlings — and this week they arrive four weeks early, ahead of Overload NZ! Property magnate Beau Ashgrove-Pemberton has commissioned a private green room for the convention floor: a gilded cosplay armor rack, a personal steamer for eleven costume changes, and — his words — “a boba station worthy of the badge line.” He simply couldn’t attend a convention without one, he tells me. Champagne wishes, caviar dreams, and now, apparently, a lanyard.

Robin Leach



FIELD DISPATCH · THE WORLD BULLETIN

Live From the Bellevue Lane Leaderboard, Slightly Chalk-Covered

Reporting live from what this paper can only describe as an arms race in erasable chalk, Baxter Kline leaned in for a close-up of the gold-marker streak just as the sandwich board it was written on tipped, gently, directly onto him. He continued narrating — “unprecedented competitive spirit among Auckland’s trivia community” — from flat on his back, one leg still in frame, entirely unbothered, entirely covered in chalk dust shaped roughly like a scoreboard.

Baxter Kline — “This has been The World Bulletin. I’m Baxter Kline, and I believe I am currently the leaderboard.”



THE SILENT MAJORITY REPORT

On the Matter of the Bellevue Lane Leaderboard

They will tell you a chalkboard trivia ranking is a trivial matter, beneath comment. I have found, in my long experience, that the press consistently underestimates precisely the things the great silent majority actually keeps score of — they kept score in ’68, they kept score of the tapes, they will certainly keep score of who holds an eleven-week streak on their own lane. Let the commentators sneer at gold marker. A nation that still organizes itself around a leaderboard, however small, retains more competitive discipline than certain foreign delegations I once sat across a table from, and said so, at length, in 1972.

Richard Nixon

IN MEMORIAM

The Anonymous Trivia Night

Skeletor

Bellevue Lane’s trivia nights once passed without a single name chalked anywhere, scores kept, if at all, in someone’s head and forgotten by Tuesday. That privacy is finished. Four leaderboards now rank the district’s regulars in gold marker, and I am told the practice began after one café simply wished to “poach custom.” A modest ambition, as these things go — I have personally conquered kingdoms for less. Mourn your anonymity if you valued it. Yours is now a matter of public record, same as everyone else’s.

GOSSIP · OVERHEARD

Darling, Everyone on Meadowbank Already Knows Who Beak That Is

The Stickybeak

The Swan, loves, is an open secret to absolutely everyone on the strip except, delightfully, our own editor. Ask any barista on Meadowbank and they’ll tell you, behind a cupped hand and not very quietly, exactly whose lunch shift that costume covers. Your Stickybeak isn’t printing the name. Your Stickybeak doesn’t have to. Gordon will find out the way he finds out everything: last.

WEATHER · THIS WEEK

A High Holds, and So Does Everyone’s Nerve

Dana Foley

A rare stalled high keeps Auckland at sixteen degrees and dry clean through the weekend — the kind of settled, undramatic pattern that offers nothing to brace for and, frankly, I don’t fully trust it. Enjoy the sunshine. Watch the western horizon anyway. It’s done nothing yet, which is exactly the sort of thing a front says right before it does something.



PUZZLE OF THE WEEK

The Short Till

Last week’s Sizing Queue, resolved in full: clues one and three together pin Reo to Small and Sana to Medium (Sana bigger than Reo, but never Large), leaving Tama the Large cup by elimination. Clue two hands Tama’s Large cup the grass jelly; clue four then rules aloe out of the Small cup, leaving Reo with pearls and Sana with the aloe — the only reading every clue survives at once.

1. Ana: “I didn’t do it.”
2. Beti: “Cy did it.”
3. Cy: “Beti is lying.”

A notch past our usual warm-up · exactly one of the three statements above is true, and exactly one of the three shorted today’s till. Who was it? Answer next week — Ken Endo

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RURAL REPORT · WHITLOCK’S ROUND

Pasture Cover Steady, and Grover’s Still Talking

Clem Whitlock

Herd testing held steady this week, nothing dramatic either way, which round here counts as good news all on its own. Grover reckons the whole district’s gone soft, judging by how much fuss got made over some chalkboard and a costume down in town. I told him a paddock doesn’t rank itself either, and he didn’t have much to say back to that.

THE BOBA SIDE

IMAGE-GENERATION PROMPT — NOT RENDERED ARTWORK

Prompt: Chibi sports-manga panel; bold rounded linework; chalk-white and gold-marker yellow on blackboard black; 4-koma comedic pacing; petty-triumphant atmosphere; flat cel-shaded finish, bold sound-effect typography. An original chibi fly character in a tiny victor’s pose atop a café chalkboard leaderboard, front legs raised in triumph, a cluster of other flies gasping from the specials-board ledge below.

"ELEVEN WEEKS. UNDEFEATED."

The Boba Side — prompt script, awaiting illustration